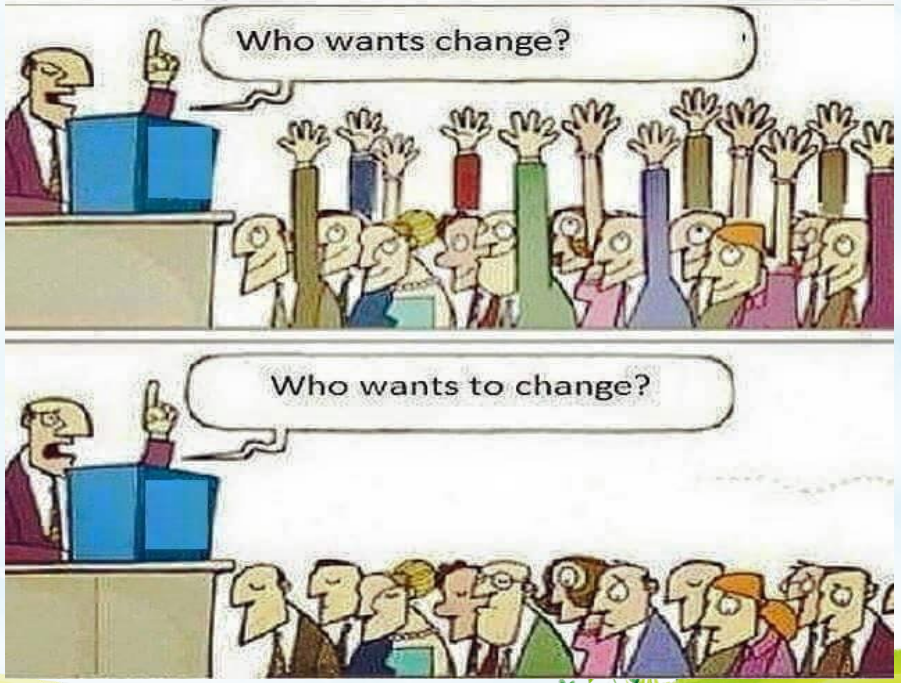
Recap of last session

- What is curriculum (vs syllabus)?
- *What are the different types of curriculum?*
- How is a centrally created curriculum implemented?
- *What are the benefits and problems of each model of curriculum implementation?*
- What is washback?
- *What are the functions carried out by high-stakes examinations?*

Curriculum innovation -> **Assessment** innovation



Assessment innovation

From *assessment of learning*

to *assessment for learning* and assessment *as* learning

From **summative** testing to **formative** assessment

What are the differences?

Session 3.
Formative assessment for the classroom:
Key Strategies and Techniques

Updated on Sept 08, 2026

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FA techniques for Young Learners

• **Thumbs Up/Down or Traffic Light Cards:** Quick check for understanding, where students show a thumbs up/down or display a green/yellow/red card to indicate their confidence with a concept.

• **Draw and Tell:** Students draw a picture to show what they've learned and explain it to a partner or the teacher.

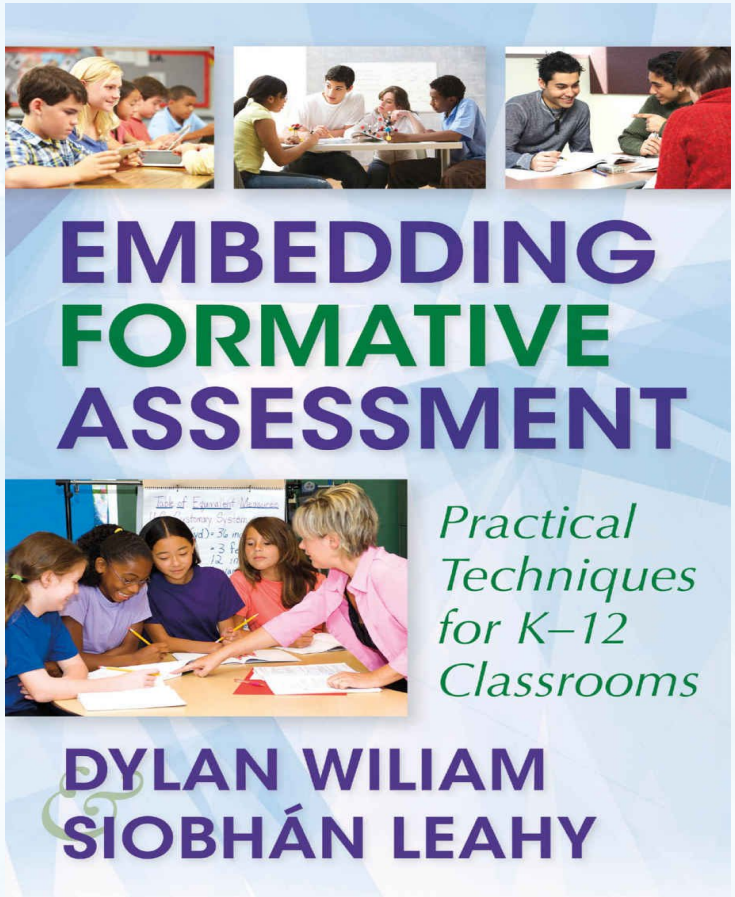
• **Learning Intention Posters:** Use posters that visualize learning goals and success criteria for students to refer to and discuss.

• **Use Smiley Face for Self-Assessment:** Students circle a smiley, neutral, or sad face to rate their work or how they feel about their learning.

• **Exit Tickets:** Ask a simple question as students leave the classroom (e.g., "What did you learn today?") and collect their answers.

Key reference

https://www.amazon.com/Embedding-Formative-Assessment-Techniques-Classrooms/dp/1941112293



Learning processes Agents	Where the learner is going	Where the learner is now	How to get there
Teacher	FAS1. Clarifying, sharing and understanding learning intentions and success criteria	FAS2. Engineering effective discussions, tasks and activities that elicit evidence of learning	FAS3. Providing feedback that moves learning forward
Peer		FAS4. Activating students as learning resources for one another	
Learner		FAS5. Activating students as owners of their own learning	

William & Leahy 2015

Strategy 1

Clarify and share

learning intentions and success criteria



Strategy 1 Clarifying, sharing, and understanding learning intentions and success criteria

- "Starting with **the end** in mind''

  (Covey, 1989, cited in Williams & Leahy, 2015, p. 27)

- "If you don't know *where you are going*, you might wind up somewhere else".

  (Yogi Berra, basketball player, ibid)

Tips

- Do not set learning objectives in a mechanical*, mindless* way, but *select, analyze, and modify them* according to your classroom and students.
- Help students develop good judgment of work quality
- Start with **samples of work** to communicate quality (e.g., *use anonymous work*; *compare two or three pieces of work*)
  - Use rubrics (評分標準) to discuss quality/success criteria
  - Ask students to reflect on what they have learned at the end of a learning unit (reflective learning: PMI method)

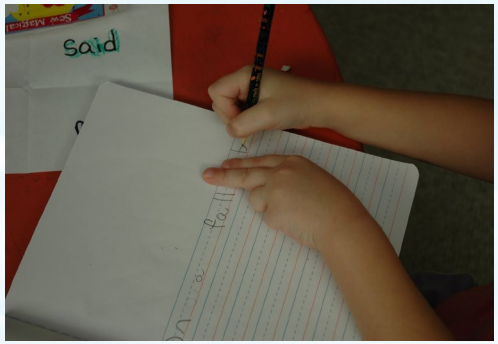
Example 1 (from p. 42)

Success criteria can be a simple checklist of features that need to be presented in a piece of good work, such as the following checklist.

Young learners are asked to check the list before submitting their work.

Yes ☺ No ☹

- All my sentences start with a capital letter.
- *Every sentence ends with a 'stop sign' ('.' '?' or '!')*
- I used finger spacing between words.
- *I used the word wall to spell my words correctly.*
- My handwriting is neat.
- *I have read through my work to make sure it sounds right.*



Case analysis. 1

Secondary school 10th-grade (S4) students are preparing for a formal written examination that will assess their understanding of English literature.

The teacher shares with the students a handout of success criteria associated with four grades (A*, A, B, C) for the exam they are about to take.

(p.54-55)

- Instead of telling the students what the success criteria for each grade is, the teacher asks the students to discuss with a partner the key differences between each descriptor and to decide which descriptor applies to which grade.
- Afterwards, she led a whole-class discussion to understand the criteria
- What do you think, which one is A* or A?

• **Shows originality of analysis and interpretation** • **Sustained evidence of enthusiastic and personal responses** • **Shows concise textual analysis and understanding** A*	• **Demonstrates insight** • **Explores connections between texts** • **Explores how meaning is conveyed through language, structure and form** • **Explores connections between texts-refers to some detail**
• Demonstrates analytical skill • Shows independent understanding • Shows layers of meaning-how meaning is conveyed through appropriate detail • Show relevant comparisons	• Demonstrates analytical and interpretative skill • Explores alternative approaches and interpretations • Considers and evaluates the way that meaning is conveyed through language, structure and form. A

Using rubrics: Pros and Cons

- **Using rubrics** can efficiently clarify 'success criteria.'
- But some rubrics can be very specific, focusing solely on what a student needs to do to complete a task. Such a rubric is useful for a summative assessment.
- **To support learning (FA)**, ***rubrics must be generic*** enough to apply ***to multiple tasks (over an extended period)*** so that the teacher can use the rubrics **multiple times**.
- Ss also need to apply the rubrics **multiple times** to gradually understand and internalize the features that characterize *quality work* across a range of tasks, but not merely rely on one 'rubric' to cope with a certain task.

Strategy 2

Engineering ***effective discussions, tasks, and activities*** that *elicit (引出)* evidence of learning



- In the classroom, **questioning** is often used as a strategy to *elicit* evidence of learning

- but is often not used effectively.

Effective questioning

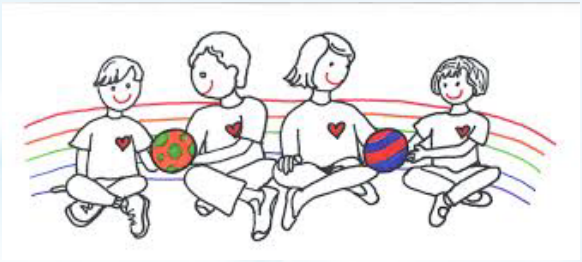
- No hands up, except for asking questions

Picking students who raise their hands won't effectively help you know your students' learning because only those who know the answers raise their hands.

Teachers need to find a way to choose students at random



Basketball technique:



- Passing questions around the classroom like a basketball.

After selecting a student to respond to a question, teachers could evaluate the response themselves (QRF pattern).

Alternatively, ***ask another student (****randomly) to decide whether the response is correct.*

A third student can be asked to explain for the first and the second student.

Hot-seat technique

Choosing students at random increases students' engagement but may create flat classroom dialogue, that is, it is hard to build deep dialogue with students.

For that purpose, it is sometimes helpful to **put a student in the hot seat**. After a student answers a question, you/the class can follow up with *a second, a third, and a fourth question* to probe in depth the students' thinking about the problem at hand.

To ensure the other students are on task, randomly *select another student* to **summarize** what the student on the hot seat has said.

Give wait time to think and elaborate

- Research showed (Rowe, 1970) that teachers commonly allow less than a second after the end of a question for students to respond
- In less than a second, teachers begin to evaluate what the student had said (too quickly, even before the student had finished speaking) (wait for Ss' elaboration)
- The research suggests teachers allow at least 3 seconds for thinking and elaboration.



Tips for effective questioning

- Plan the questions you will use to elicit students' responses
- Use **wh questions** but not Yes or No questions, asking 'do you understand?' won't get you far.
- Using the following question shells:

1. How are … and …different/similar?
2. *What is the difference between …and …?*
3. Can you explain why…?
4. *Can you give an example of …?*
5. Why should we use … but not …?

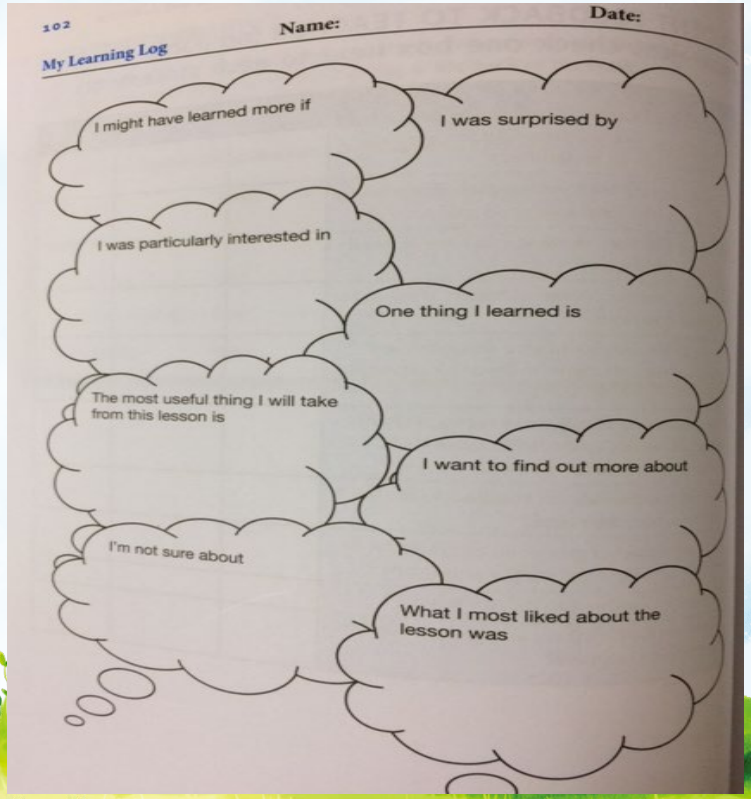
Questioning: Dos and Don'ts

(G. Brown & Wragg, 1993)

Asking X (Don'ts)	Failing to ✓ (Dos)
Too many questions at once	Correct wrong answers
A question and answer it yourself	Give students the time to think
Questions only for the brightest	Pay attention to answers
A difficult question too early	See the implications of answers
Questions in a threatening way	Build on answers
Irrelevant questions *Same kind of questions all the time*	

Elicit evidence of learning by collecting student feedback

1. I might have learned more if …
2. *I was surprised by …*
3. I was particularly interested in …
4. *One thing I learned is…*
5. The most useful thing I will take from this lesson is …
6. *I want to find out more about …*
7. I am not sure about …
8. *What I most liked about this lesson was….*



Strategy 3

Providing feedback that moves learning forward





Tips for Effective Feedback

- 1. Feedback should be **acted upon** by the recipient (if not, it is a waste of time).

- 2. Don't give feedback on everything students do (**being selective**).

(William and Leahy, 2015, p. 121)

Tips for Effective Feedback

- 3. Feedback should be more work for who than who Making teacher feedback sustainable.
- ” (Jackson, 2009).

Why?

- 4. Provide what of critical and supportive feedback.

5. Make sure your feedback is read and understood without emotion

Example 1

A teacher provided her comments on four students' essays in four strips of paper separated from the essays.

In returning her feedback, she asked the four students to match the comments to the essays.

Because the comments have no **identification of the student**, the students have to read carefully and look for the meaning of the comments rather than their personal significance.

6. Categorizing strengths and weaknesses

- Example

A teacher used two colors to mark her students' essays: green for strengths and red for weaknesses.



Students are **required to annotate** *what is positive* about the features highlighted in green and *what is weak* about those highlighted in red.

Teachers do not need to provide detailed comments, but use colors to signal their judgment, while students need to think and interpret the colored parts.



Example

The teacher used a colored pen to mark on her student's writing simply to indicate the location of the errors (indirect error correction).

She returned the work to students, and

Students had to

a. Identify the kinds of errors they made (e.g. tense, SVA, adjective-noun agreement, etc.), and
b. Draw a bar chart that shows the errors they made the most often,
c. Use this bar chart, teachers pair up students with complementary strengths and weaknesses to provide **mutual support** to each other.

7. Give focused feedback but not correct everything

- Too much feedback can be destructive (*red-blood-sea*);

  Focus on certain features each time (e.g., plan with the learning objectives); ignore other errors.

8. Make it clear what the student is meant to do with your feedback

Give comments or directions, and make sure students will take actions on your feedback, e.g., *correct the highlighted parts, rewrite, put the errors into an error-collection bank,* etc.

Strategy 4

Activating **students**
as **learning resources** for one another



Peer assessment or feedback.

“Engaging students in assessing the work of their peers is not just a labor-saving device for teachers. *Implemented properly, it can substantially increase student achievement*, both for those who get help …and those who *provide the help*.” (p. 139)



Peer assessment

- is related to the concept of cooperative learning.
- Cooperative learning takes place ‘when students work cooperatively to accomplish shared learning goals”(Johnson et al, 1998, p.28).
- vs ‘individualistic learning’ (where students learn on their own)
- vs ‘competitive learning’ (where students strive to be better than others).

Tip 1. Use pair work (easy to arrange, higher level of engagement):

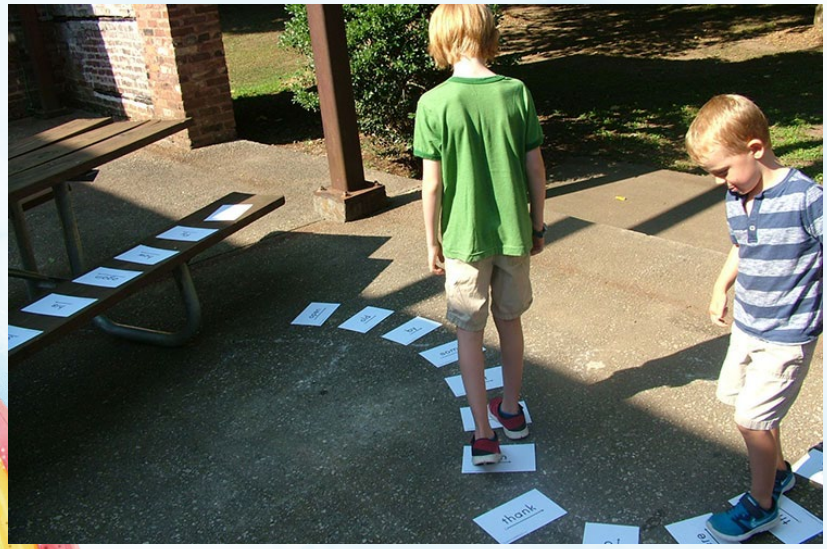
Example-1: **Fry words** (Edward Fry, 1980)

- **A teacher** made sets of 100 small cards of 100 most common words in English.
- Pairs of students are given three circular rugs in red, yellow, and green.
  - **Ss** take turns testing each other on the words.
  - One selects a card and shows it to the other, who has to read the word aloud.
  - If the S reads the word correctly on the first attempt, the card is placed on the green rug.
  - If she/he does so on the 2nd attempt, the card is placed on the yellow rug.
  - If she/he is unsuccessful, it is placed on the red rug.
  - **The Ss can use the cards on the red/yellow rug to review**
  - The students then swap roles. (p.144)



Alternatives: pairs or groups

Sight words pathway



Bean bag toss



Find more games at https://sightwords.com/sight-words/games/

Tip 2. Model effective feedback

Example-2

- Begin with a whole-class session, *where students are asked to provide feedback on the work of an anonymous work*
- Purpose:
- Then, take a couple of works of actual students for the whole class to critique
- Then start a peer-assessment session

Tip 3. Provide a feedback structure

Example 1

- "Two stars and a wish"

When doing peer feedback, students identify two positive features of the work (the "stars") and one suggestion for how the student can improve the work (the 'wish').

- This technique provides a feedback structure that helps build students' ability to give sensitive and constructive feedback to their peers.

An extension of the “Two Stars & One Wish” technique:

- Use self-adhesive notes (Post-it) of different colors (green for stars and pink for a wish) to provide feedback to each other.
- *Collect the pink notes and place them together, then*
- *Lead a whole-class discussion about the relative merits of these comments.*
- This follow-up improves peer feedback and introduces ‘individual accountability’

ABC feedback structure



- **A**gree with: areas of agreement
- **B**uild on: suggestions for how areas/arguments can be strengthened
- **C**hallenge: suggestions for addition or more substantial changes

Provide sentence starters:

- “I like the way you…”
- “You did an excellent job of…”
- “I thought it was very effective when you…”
- “My favorite part was …”
- “I was surprised that …”
- “ I didn’t understand …”
- “ I was puzzled that …”
- “ I think it would be clearer if …”
- “ A perhaps better way to express this may be…”

Tip 4. Agree on ground rules for peer feedback

- **Ground rules** can be general and vague at the beginning, such as '*make sure comments are helpful*' or '*make sure to provide suggestions for the problems identified*.'
- Can **be developed gradually.**
- Can be **posted on the walls** (as visual reminders)

5. Structure goals and rewards to promote group cooperation as well as individual accountability

e.g., A teacher tells a group of students that they have to work together to learn something, but at the end of the activity, she will test them individually and award each the mean score (average)* of the group.

*Or the highest/lowest score

Why?

The purpose is to create incentives for group work while maintaining individual accountability (no free riders).

Strategy 5

Activating students as
owners of their own learning: **Autonomy**



Self-assessment

"Most of what our students need to know hasn't been discovered or invented yet. 'Learning how to learn' used to be *an optional* extra in education. Today, it is *a survival skill*." (p.169)

Self-assessment is crucial for students to become self-regulated learners and to enable life-long learning.

Less is more

- “The test of a successful education is *not the amount of knowledge* that a pupil takes away from school, but his appetite to know and his capacity to learn. If the school sends out children with a desire for knowledge and some idea of how to acquire and use it, it will have done its work.
- Too many (Ss) leave school with that appetite killed and the mind loaded with undigested lumps of information.
- The good schoolmaster is known by the number of valuable subjects that he declines to teach.

- (Sir Richard Livingstone, President of Corpus Christi College
  - at the University of Oxford, 1941, p.28; cited in p. 169)

1. Key strategy

Helping students take greater **ownership** of their own work and, in turn, increasing their achievement (Barkat, 2014).

- Setting learning activities in the context of *personal goals*
- e.g., connecting school learning to career aspirations
- Connecting effort to success (e.g., cultivating a growth mindset)
- Engaging students in the **planning** of the work
- (e.g., give choice of tasks and provide a tool for keeping track of work)

Examples



- Use a simple 3-color system for students to **self-assess** and **signal to teachers** their learning progress. Each color is associated with a clear standard

e.g.

- Green: *I am ready to explain the concept to someone else;*
- Yellow: I have a question, but it is not stopping me from working.
- Red: *I am stuck, and I can't make any progress until someone comes to help.*

2. Make self-report *consequential but not too much*

Example

- Teachers gave each student three colored plastic cups.
- At the beginning, the cups are nested so that the green cup is shown.
- To signal that the lesson is going too fast, a student displays the yellow cup, and to stop the lesson to ask a question, the student displays the red cup.
- As soon as a red cup is shown, the teacher can *select another student with a green cup to help* the student showing the red cup.
- In this example, teachers can receive students' feedback on teaching instantly (to adjust teaching pace). Students' self-assessment is consequential (takes effect, leading to actions and change). (p.175), **but a limit is set on the consequence.**

The plus-minus-interesting (PMI) technique

- At the end of a task, ask students to identify one thing they found easy about the task (a plus +), one thing they found difficult about the task (a minus -), and one thing they found interesting.
- Comments (data/information) can be efficiently collected in a number of ways, e.g., *have all students write them on a big sheet of paper with 3 columns and post it on a wall*;
- Use colored adhesive notes and paste them on a board or on a wall, etc.

The plus-minus-interesting method can bring a number of benefits.

- 1. Teachers can quickly judge whether the task is appropriate for students and for whom it is too easy or too hard; what aspects are too hard or too easy, which is useful information for regrouping or adjusting the level of difficulty of their worksheets.

- 2. It also gets students to reflect on the work they have done and to become more precise in identifying their problems and asking for help.

3. Make self-assessment a routine part of classwork

Let students keep learning portfolios and reflect on and assess their own work continuously.

By giving students time to generate a sense of ownership of their learning, teachers covered the content more slowly, but

they found that because the coverage was deeper, they needed to do much less re-teaching. (p. 179)

4. Engage students as lesson observers

a. Train a group of students (so they can rotate) in your class to act as *lesson observers* and provide feedback to you
b. Organize the observation (e.g., set up a schedule)
c. Prepare suitable observation forms/checklists
d. Use students as *videographers* (create video recordings of lessons in teams of three: one cameraman, one sound engineer/control, and one director). (p.196)

Recap

- 1. Clarifying, sharing, and understanding learning intentions and success criteria (setting clear and achievable targets)
- 2. Engineering effective discussion, tasks, and activities that elicit evidence of learning (collecting information of/about learning)
- 3. Providing feedback that moves learning forward

  (make sure the feedback is understood and acted upon)
- 4. Activating students as learning resources for one another
- (draw on students' time and expertise for peer assessment/feedback)
- 5. Activating students as owners of their own learning (autonomy is powerful)
  (S4&5 are also referred to as Assessment as learning)

Implementing FA in your classroom: More tips

1. Start small
2. Clarify learning goals
3. Use variety
4. Make feedback actionable
5. Foster a supportive environment
6. Leverage technology
7. **Monitor and adjust**

Key references

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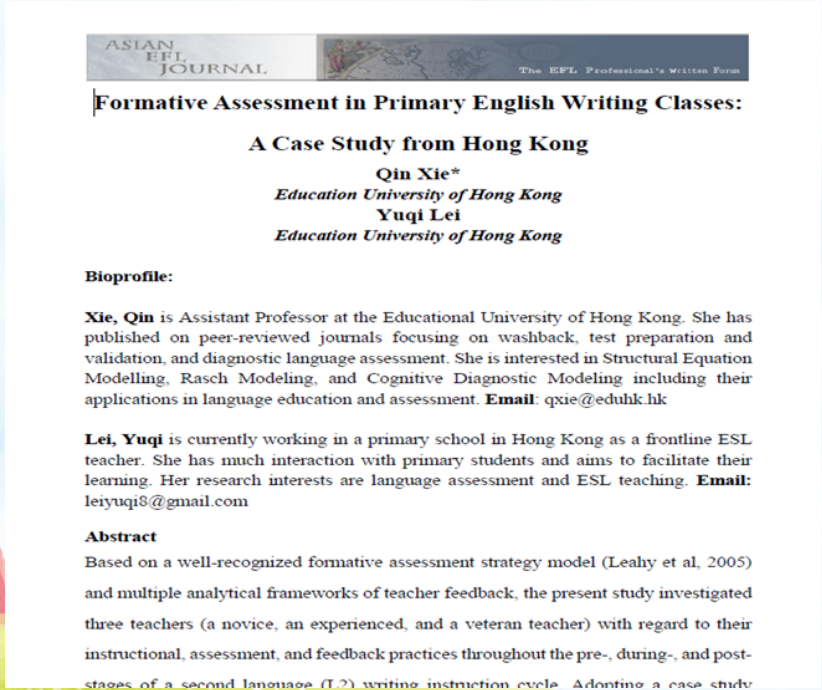
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Back Close

FA in primary EFL writing class

Xie & Lei (2019). Formative assessment in primary English writing classes: A case study from Hong Kong. *Asia EFL Journal*.



ASIAN EFL JOURNAL
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Formative Assessment in Primary English Writing Classes:

A Case Study from Hong Kong

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Abstract

Based on a well-recognized formative assessment strategy model (Leahy et al, 2005) and multiple analytical frameworks of teacher feedback, the present study investigated three teachers (a novice, an experienced, and a veteran teacher) with regard to their instructional, assessment, and feedback practices throughout the pre-, during-, and post-stages of a second language (L2) writing instruction cycle. Adopting a case study

- In the context of *teaching English writing in English in primary schools*
- We observed three teachers who applied FA strategies in teaching writing.

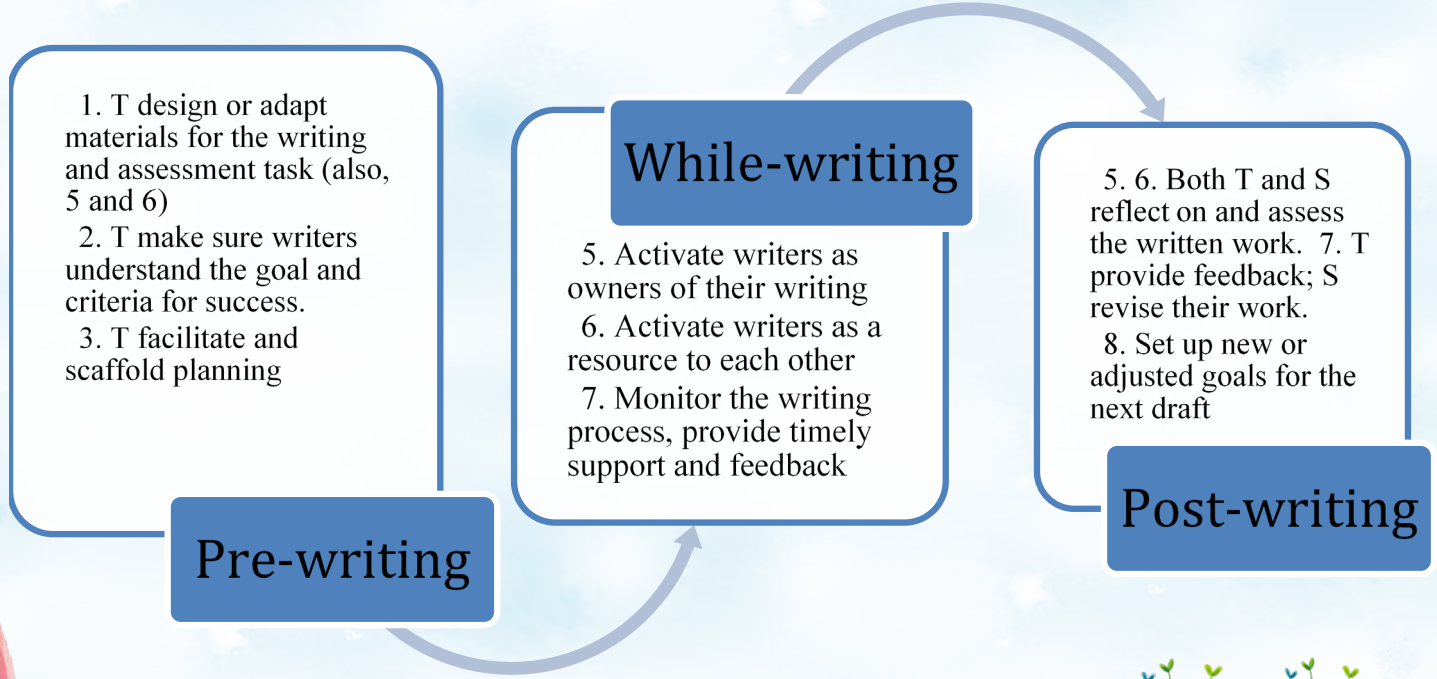
Formative Assessment in Primary English Writing Classes:

A Case Study from Hong Kong

Qin Xie
Yuqi Lei



Embedding the Five FA strategies in process-based English writing classroom



Source: Xie & Lei (2019) and Xie & Cui (2022)

More FA techniques for Upper Primary (Ages 9–12)

• **Two Stars and a Wish:** Peer or self-assessment where students identify two strengths ("stars") and one area to improve ("wish") in their own or a classmate's work.

• **Mini-Whiteboards:** Use individual whiteboards for students to write answers and show them to the teacher for instant feedback.

• **Think-Pair-Share:** Students think about a question individually, discuss with a partner, and then share with the class.

• **Quick Quizzes or Polls:** Short, non-graded quizzes to gauge understanding.

• **Learning Journals:** Regular short reflections on what they learned, what was challenging, and what they enjoyed.

More FA techniques for Lower Secondary (Ages 12–15)

• **Peer Feedback with Sentence Starters:** Structured templates for students to give feedback (e.g., "I like the way you…", "It would be even better if…").

• **Self-Assessment Checklists:** Students use checklists to monitor their own progress toward learning goals.

• **Concept Mapping:** Students create a mind map or diagram to show how ideas connect.

• **Hot Seat Questioning:** Randomly select a student to answer a question, then have others add, clarify, or expand on the answer.

• **Plus-Minus-Interesting (PMI) Charts:** Students list positives, negatives, and interesting points about a lesson or concept.

More FA techniques for Upper Secondary (Ages 15 up)

Annotated Exemplars: Analyze and annotate samples of work to identify strengths and weaknesses.

•**Peer Review Workshops:** Structured sessions where students review and give feedback on each other's drafts using analytic rubrics.

•**Socratic Seminars:** Students engage in guided discussions, using evidence from texts to support their ideas.

•**Online Polls and Surveys:** Use tools like Google Forms, Kahoot, or Padlet for real-time feedback or reflection.

•**Learning Portfolios:** Students collect and reflect on their work overtime, setting goals for improvement.